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MARIANNE MOORE AND THE NEW YORK SCHOOL: O'HARA, ASHBERY, KOCH

As the eighties pass, critics increasingly recognize the major stature of Marianne Moore's poetry. In 1981, Bonnie Costello's *Imaginary Possessions* envisioned not "the timid, frightened lady in the black hat," but "a poet whose most persuasive images are those of combat and warfare" (Martin 7). Moore's newly published *Collected Prose* exhibits her delight in the boxer Cassius Clay, the "smiling pugilist" for whose record album *I am the Greatest!* she composed the liner notes in 1963. Still, the misapprehending myth persists. For example, John Ashbery has recently been misquoted as calling her "a Mary Poppins of poetry." In a 1967 review of her *Complete Poems*, he does not condone but characterizes those who underestimate her:

Is she not a sort of Mary Poppins of poetry, or, to state the case against her as quickly as possible, an American La Fontaine, who, great poet that he is, always seems to be on the verge of becoming a tiresome moralist like Joubert or even Poor Richard?

He corrects such views, however, by insisting that "she is not a moralist or an antiquarian, but a poet writing on many levels at once to produce work of an irreducible symphonic texture," and exhibiting "a mastery which defies attempts to analyze it, an intelligence which plays just beyond our reach." "These are not the manners of a governess, whether endowed with magical powers or not," he concludes. Her work contains "that magic which consists in awakening sensations with the help of a combination of sounds . . . that sorcery by which ideas are necessarily communicated to us, in a definite way, by words which nevertheless do not express them." The meaning in her poetry, as in music, is more than the sum of its structure.

Such emphatic championing by a distinguished postmodern poet suggests that the extent of Moore's accomplishments may become more visible in hindsight.

Nevertheless, certain recent studies neglect her, tending to name Auden as sole forerunner of the postmoderns. Correcting this oversight is Taffy Martin's study *Marianne Moore: Subversive Modernist*, which makes a particularly strong case for relating the work of Moore to the postmoderns.

A valuable way to approach this topic would be to single out those poetic practices of Moore's that seem "post-modern" or more accurately, if more horribly, "pre-post-modern" and which set precedents for the New York School poets afterwards. Part of the challenge would be to sort out from the postmodern bag those elements which could be identified specifically as Moore's legacy, as opposed, for instance, to Stevens's, Pound's, or Williams's. Frank O'Hara cites Stevens and Pound, along with Moore, Olson, and Auden, for "instances of remarkable and strong design" (*Standing Still* 34). Though Ashbery's influences clearly include Stevens, as well as composers Cage and Webern, his taste in predecessors has focused on Moore for some decades. In reviewing *Tell Me, Tell Me*, he claimed her as, "with the possible exception of Pound and Auden, the greatest living poet in English" ("Jerboas"). He elaborates in a later review:

I am tempted simply to call her our greatest modern poet. This despite the obvious grandeur of her chief competitors, including Wallace Stevens and William Carlos Williams. It seems we can never remind ourselves too often that universality and depth are not the same thing. MM has no *Arma virumque cano* prefacing her work: she even avoids formal beginnings altogether... But her work will, I think, continue to be read as poetry when much of the major poetry of our time has become part of the history of literature. ("Straight Lines")

What elements so attract Ashbery to Moore's work? Martin claims that Moore's poetic "patterning bears the marks of other artists whose works have become reference points for postmodernism." Her poems

make one think of John Cage's music, in which artificial time constraints and found sounds replace traditional phrasing. Moore's attention to curious objects, her refusal to set most poems into a recognizable narrative, and her nearly too startling metaphors become not precious mannerisms but postmodern credentials when they appear in Frank O'Hara's poems. (Martin xii)

Other postmodern elements include "accuracy, patterning, and repetition"; inclusivity of "irresolvable multiplicity" rather than defensiveness or escapism; acknowledgment and

exploitation of the machine; and scientifically accurate observation. Calling Moore's work "a continuous fictive discourse that replaces the lyre of traditional poetry with everyday words and with heretical ideas about language itself" (xiii), Martin might be describing the poems of Ashbery, Koch, and O'Hara.

As these younger poets would do, Moore "leads her readers to expect traditional images, solutions, and verbal structures; but she gives them images that dissolve, epigrammatic endings that solve nothing, and quotations that disfigure rather than preserve speech" (Martin xiv). Like theirs, her poetry proceeds by discursive engagement, positing an "I" and "thou" as argumentative poles or as mentor and hearer. All use paradox, mystery, word play, and ironies that refuse to open readily to a reader who approaches the work casually. Says Martin, "she admits the insufficiency of her fictive constructs and argues for radical ambiguity and indeterminacy as positive alternatives," shaping both content and form of the poem from disordered co-ordinates. Many of these elements can be quickly exhibited, handled with a kind of ultimate self-consciousness, in Ashbery's "And *Ut Pictura Poesis* is Her Name" (*Selected Poems* 235):

You can't say it that way any more.
 Bothered about beauty you have to
 Come out into the open, into a clearing,
 And rest. Certainly whatever funny happens to you
 Is OK. To demand more than this would be strange
 Of you, you who have so many lovers,
 People who look up to you and are willing
 To do things for you, but you think
 It's not right, that if they really knew you...
 So much for self-analysis. Now,
 About what to put in your poem-painting:
 Flowers are always nice, particularly delphinium.
 Names of boys you once knew and their sleds,
 Skyrockets are good--do they still exist?
 There are a lot of other things of the same quality
 As those I've mentioned. Now one must
 Find a few important words, and a lot of low-keyed,
 Dull-sounding ones. She approached me
 About buying her desk. Suddenly the street was
 Bananas and the clangor of Japanese instruments.
 Humdrum testaments were scattered about. His head
 Locked into mine. We were a seesaw. Something
 Ought to be written about how this affects
 You when you write poetry:
 The extreme austerity of an almost empty mind
 Colliding with the lush, Rousseau-like foliage of its desire to
 communicate

Something between breaths, if only for the sake
 Of others and their desire to understand you and desert you
 For other centers of communication, so that understanding
 May begin, and in doing so be undone.

There are still other similarities of structure, motif and meaning, taste and temperament, shared by Moore, Ashbery, Koch, and O'Hara. All were drawn to the French tradition, Moore dedicating much of her later career to a "translation"--actually, a recasting--of La Fontaine's fables; the three younger poets adopting and championing the writings of the surrealists, Eluard, Jacob, Apollinaire, Giorgio de Chirico, Arthur Cravan, Raymond Roussel. Her poems, like theirs, often observe artworks--paintings or sculptures, as in "When I Buy Pictures" and "No Swan So Fine"; animals, as in "Peter" or "The Monkeys"; or "people's surroundings"--landscapes, cityscapes, interiors. She freely shifts from such locales to considerations of language, poetic creation, and truth, like "England," which begins with landscapes, then discusses "plain American which cats and dogs can read!" and ends by claiming that superiority "has never been confined to one locality" (*Complete Poems* 46-47). So Ashbery's claim, implicitly, in a poem entitled "As You Came from the Holy Land"--"of western New York state," as the first line continues (*Selected Poems* 167).

In her poems and theirs, paradox and mystery are presented in a language so precise as to constitute, in itself, another dimension of riddle. O'Hara could speak as an irresolvable multiplicity of selves in "In Memory of My Feelings" (*Selected Poems* 105-110), contained within immediacy by his creation of the poem. Ashbery's long poem "The Skaters" (*Selected Poems* 171) may be compared to Moore's masterpiece, "An Octopus" (*Complete Poems* 71), for landscape imagery, abrupt and dazzling juxtapositions, sudden turns, lists and quotations, levels of meaning, multiple voices, and musicality. Koch's playful puns and word-changes in "Lunch"--"O launch, lunch, you dazzling hoary tunnel to paradise!" (*Selected Poems* 55)--are used by Moore in such poems as "Efforts of Affection": "Genesis tells us of Jubal and Jabal. / One handled the harp and one herded the cattle" (*Complete Poems* 147). And Koch's obsessive descriptiveness in "The Railway Stationery" (*Selected Poems* 64) shows a scientific method as exacting as any of Moore's zoological detail. Nevertheless, I must at least repeat Martin's caveat, that Moore's self-devised poetic forms did not permit her the kind of open-endedness valued and exploited by the New York School group:

She does not blow apart the familiar world in order to create her own energetic system. While she reactivates meaning by loosening form from statement, she never violates the rules of composition. This allows her to rebel without culpability or offense ... Moore's syntax is impeccable, if not cooperative, (161)

whereas that of the New York School poets is often run over and through.

At first sight, caveats of all kinds appear to be in order. For example, it seems a daunting task to descry similarities between the intentionally self-structured work of Marianne Moore and that of Frank O'Hara. His long, rambling odes, a form used by his French and Russian masters as well as by Koch and Ashbery, seem unrelated to Moore's precisely designed stanzas, although she too occasionally chose a free discursiveness. But O'Hara's work, like that of Koch and Ashbery, often exhibits more complex poetic patterns. He continually turned to sonnets and drama, and his earlier pieces show him experimenting with a whole bouquet of forms--humorous dirges in strophes and antistrophes, triolets, madrigals, epitaphs, pastorals, poems in French, portraits and parodies of Joyce, Auden, Wordsworth and Shelley. It seems unlikely that he would hesitate to take what he valued from Moore's inventions. And O'Hara does imitate Moore's familiar title-into-poem maneuver, in such pieces as "Having a Coke with You," with a second line "is even more fun than going to San Sebastian" (*Selected Poems* 175).

Moore and O'Hara also share certain temperaments. Both have a rhapsodic side; for example, in poems that directly address the sun. If O'Hara is following Mayakovsky, as in "A True Account of Talking to the Sun on Fire Island" (*Selected Poems* 138), Moore is quoting man-as-pangolin, who "says to the alternating blaze, / 'Again the sun! / anew each day; and new and new and new, / that comes into and steadies my soul'" (*Complete Poems* 117). Both address animals with a sense of nostalgia for Eden, of an alternative otherness to human life. O'Hara's impassioned apostrophes are surely not foreign to those of Moore, as in "In Distrust of Merits" (*Complete Poems* 136):

... O shining O
firm star, O tumultuous
ocean lashed till small things go
as they will, the mountainous
wave makes us who look, know

depth. Lost at sea before they fought! O
 star of David, star of Bethlehem,
 O black imperial lion
 of the Lord--emblem
 of a risen world--be joined at last, be
 joined....

 ... that I
 may yet recover from the disease, My
 Self; some have it lightly; some will die. "Man's
 wolf to man" and we devour
 ourselves.

Although O'Hara's sense of self, of selves, is far more hysterical and exposed than Moore's, what may surprise us is that Moore's vision can be just as dark.

We can see the questing self-questioning for meaning of Moore in O'Hara and in Ashbery (as also in Elizabeth Bishop's and James Schuyler's quick parenthetical asides). O'Hara replied, when asked in an interview (*Standing Still* 14), "What's the criterion of truth in poetry?"

Where you don't find that someone is making themselves more elegant, more stupid, more appealing, more affectionate or more sincere than the words will allow them to be.

And Koch and O'Hara both follow Moore in their delighted inclusions of showbiz folks: witness Moore's "Tom Fool at Jamaica" (*Complete Poems* 163), a poem in which she says, "Well, this is a rhapsody":

Of course, speaking of champions, there was Fats Waller
 with the feather touch, giraffe eyes, and that hand alighting in
 A in't Misbehavin'! Ozzie Smith and Eubie Blake
 ennoble the atmosphere....

Compare the rhapsodic list of film stars in O'Hara's "To the Film Industry in Crisis" (*Selected Poems* 99), a comic masterpiece of accuracy, patterning, and repetition.

With these major similarities and differences established, what remains in common to the New York School and Moore? One characteristic, as Ashbery claims, is "its avoidance of anything like a program," a freedom like that of the surrealists' "grande permission." It asks that poetry

should be anything it wants to be; that the poet should be free to sit down to his desk and write as he pleases without feeling that someone is standing behind him telling him to brush up on his objective correlatives or that he's just dropped an iambic foot. (Text of speech)

So, too, Moore's poetics, as her poems set it forth: "Where there is personal liking we go," she declares in "The Hero" (*Complete Poems* 8); and, if we may read poet for cat in "Peter" (*Complete Poems* 43),

to sit caged by the rungs of a domestic chair
would be unprofitable--human. What is the good of hypocrisy?
It is permissible to choose one's employment,
to abandon the nail, or roly-poly,
when it shows signs of being no longer a pleasure,
to score the nearby magazine with a double line of strokes.
He can talk but insolently says nothing.

Similarly, Ashbery or Koch can make sense, but insolently prefer mystery. In a conversation published by Interview Press (19), they elaborate:

KOCH--There's no key to understanding the poem, of course, no hidden meaning?

ASHBERY--No, it's just a bunch of impressions.

KOCH--Why is the idea of keys and hidden meanings not appealing to you?

ASHBERY--Because someone might find them out and then the poem would no longer be mysterious.

KOCH--I feel the same. Do you use any deliberate methods to make your poems mysterious?

ASHBERY--I don't know...

Moore herself insisted that "there is power in mystery" (Martin 53). And indeed, mystery may protect a poet, as the cat's claws are its armor. Reticence and contradiction are pleasures, and "complexity is not a crime," as Moore states in "In the Days of Prismatic Color" (*Complete Poems* 41). They become one form of defense, as in O'Hara's "In Memory of My Feelings":

My quietness has a man in it, he is transparent
and he carries me quietly, like a gondola, through the streets.
He has several likenesses, like stars and years, like numerals.

My quietness has a number of naked selves,
so many pistols I have borrowed to protect myself
from creatures who too readily recognize my weapons
and have murder in their heart! (*Collected Poems* 252)

And Moore values "armor's undermining modesty" as a concomitant to her interior struggle for imaginative freedom and discovery. What appears evasive in the poet, then, may be the elusive life of the poem itself:

KOCH--Do you think the kind of art that you and I like and create might be called "evasive"? Do you think we like the feeling of ambiguity and multiple possibilities partly or wholly because we don't want to be pinned down to anything we've done or are about to do?

ASHBERY--Possibly. But I think that if we like things that are evasive it's because there is no point in pursuing something that is standing still. Anything that is standing still might as well be dead...

As Martin claims for Moore, "Her real contrast is not between natural and artificial or plain and complex, but between static and dynamic forms" (162).

Because the poem "must give pleasure," the poet must be free to define and redefine the pleasurable. He must know what he likes and must go there: a heroic effort. "You just go on your nerve," declares O'Hara in his mock-manifesto "Personism" (*Standing Still* 110). And Koch and Ashbery worry the problem:

KOCH--John, do you think we both might be too much concerned with matters of taste? or don't you think it's possible to be too much concerned with it?

ASHBERY--What else is there besides matters of taste? (5)

As Koch later recalls this exchange, in "Days and Nights" (*Selected Poems* 228):

"Taste, I said to J and he said
"What else is there?" but he was looking around.

Picking and choosing are the exercise of taste, and a poetry of quotation insists that taste be exercised. In this, Ashbery perhaps approaches most closely to Moore. As David Shapiro distinguishes, "The characteristic Ashbery tone is not that of the others. He is neither as celebratory as Koch nor as urbane and political as O'Hara" (Shapiro 26). Nor is he an autobiographical poet: David Kalstone recognizes that "Ashbery writes autobiography only inasmuch as he writes about the widening sense of what it is like to gain--or try to gain--access to his experience" (171). Charles Molesworth has called him more literary, in a hard-to-locate way (164). And he is indeed much more a man of letters, literally, in the same way that Moore was a collector of the word. We have seen that she kept intricate, fastidious, detailed records of her readings, of notebooks of what she read, of quotations that she would later return and reweave into her poetry (see, e.g., Willis 29-30). Ashbery has composed by similar picking and choosing, but with some interesting--and informative--differences. For exam-

ple, as he describes the composition of the long poem *Europe*:

I was trying to conceal the plot of a book I picked up on the quai called *Beryl of the Biplane*. At the same time I heard a piece on the radio by an Italian composer who had taken a recording of a poem by Joyce and transformed the words until they were incomprehensible but still gave an idea of the original. I got the title from the name of a subway station in Paris. It seemed to me that I was at last permitting myself to allude to Europe which had been my center of activity for several years, but by merely listing a lot of things and situations that could be found in most other places as well and by keeping the ceramic title of the subway station firmly in mind it seemed to me that I could convey the impression that Europe was just another subject, no more or less important than a lot of others....

I used some passages from *Beryl*. I think I might also have put in a few words from an article in *Esquire* as well as a mistranslation of something I saw written by an automatic toy in the museum of Neuchatel (des mécanismes précis nous animent, which I misread as nous aimant). (Ashbery/Koch 19)

Recall the fond quotation of a misquotation that Moore included in "Picking and Choosing" (*Complete Poems* 45): how one young writer, "very young and very rushed," set Caesar crossing the Alps "on the top of a 'diligence'!" Certainly, the style of Ashbery, O'Hara, and Koch would appear young and rushed to Moore. And yet it was she who blasted open the terrain of quotations within poetry for Ashbery: he can beg, borrow, and steal lines with far more ease than she, who often felt constrained to footnote sources (though there too she often let mystery and chance play more freely than at first it seems). From Ashbery's "Self-Portrait in a Convex Mirror" (*Selected Poems* 197): The locking into place is "death itself,"

As Berg said of a phrase in Mahler's Ninth;
Or, to quote Imogen in *Cymbeline*, "There cannot
Be a pinch in death more sharp than this," for,
Though only exercise or tactic, it carries
The momentum of a conviction that had been building.

Such momentum is like that of music, which certainly becomes part of the pleasure in poetic mystery. O'Hara felt

that the metrical, that the measure let us say,... comes from the breath of the person just as a stroke of paint comes from the wrist and hand and arm and shoulder and all that of the painter. So therefore the point is really more to establish one's own measure and breath in poetry... this sounds wildly ambitious since I don't think I've done it but I think that great poets do it--

rather than fitting your ideas into an established order, syllabically and phonetically and so on. (*Standing Still* 17)

Just so Moore's work. In "Efforts of Affection," Bishop praises Moore's rhythm in particular (54):

I had already made up a completely unscientific theory that Marianne was possessed of a unique, involuntary sense of rhythm, therefore of meter, quite unlike anyone else's. She looked like no one else; she talked like no one else; her poems showed a mind not much like anyone else's; and her notions of meter and rhyme were unlike all the conventional notions--so why not believe that the old English meters that still seem natural to most of us were not natural to her at all? That Marianne from birth, physically, had been set going to a different rhythm?

In her stanzaic experiments, Moore creates a new measure for each poem, setting the poem into form by means of a first, randomly generated stanza, then fitting each following stanza to the requirements of that pattern. This method suggests how her poetry fulfills Ashbery's taste for musicality. He has written, in an introduction for an edition of *The Tennis Court Oath*,

I feel I could express myself best in music. What I like about music is its ability of being convincing, of carrying an argument through successfully to the finish, though the terms of this argument remain unknown quantities. What remains is the structure, the architecture of the argument, scene, or story. I would like to do this in poetry.

So the paradoxical "Jelly-Fish" in Moore's poem (*Complete Poems* 180):

Visible, invisible,
a fluctuating charm
an amber-tinctured amethyst
inhabits it, your arm
approaches and it opens
and it closes; you had meant
to catch it and it quivers;
you abandon your intent.

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